LODESTAR USER GUIDE · 121 SQN

Ops Room

Running the day board

DRAFT · NOT FOR ISSUE · 6 NOVEMBER 2026

Who this guide is for

This guide is for the SDO / AOS on duty and the Ops Room staff: the day's flight board, the seats, closing flights, Ops Add, the AFP and the daily ATOM export.

In this guide

Part 1 Getting started: how LODESTAR works, how to open it, and how your work is saved.

Part 2 Ops Room: the day board for the SDO / AOS on duty and the projector.

Start with **Part 1, Getting started**. The contents on the next page give the page of every section. Every page in the dashboard also has its own help: press the **?** button at the right end of the tab bar.

LODESTAR · 121 SQN · **Ops Room guide** · Dated 6 November 2026 · For dashboard version z196 (BETA) · Screenshots use demo data only: the names, callsigns and flights are made up.

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PART 1

Getting started

How LODESTAR works, how to open it, and how your work is saved

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1.1 What LODESTAR is

LODESTAR is the squadron's daily flying and ops planner. It replaces copying plans by hand between the department Excel files and the Ops Room. It has two pieces:

- **Eight Excel files** in the SharePoint folder **Program**. They hold all the data. They have no macros and still open normally in Excel.
- **The dashboard**, one web page in the same folder. It opens the Excel files, shows them as planners, calendars and boards, and saves your changes back into them.

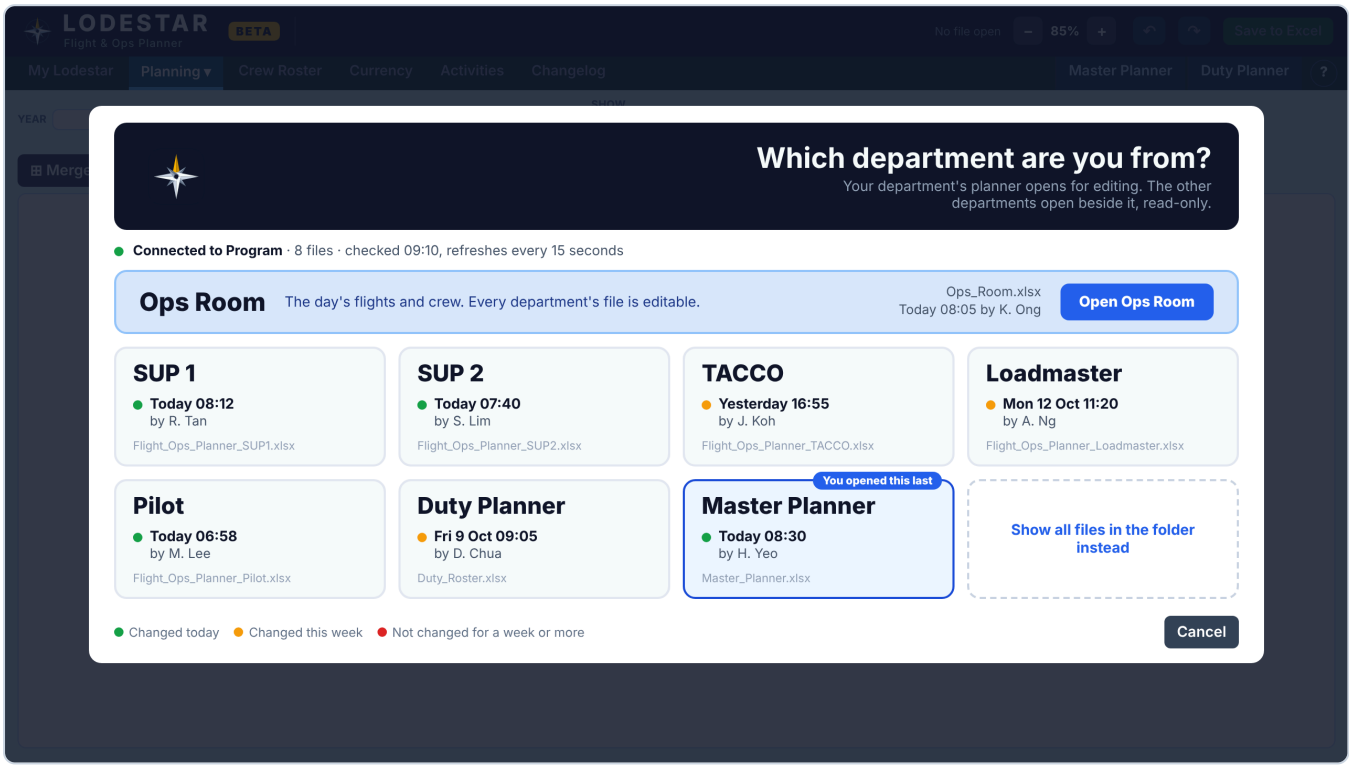
File	What it holds
Flight_Ops_Planner_SUP1, _SUP2, _TACCO, _Loadmaster, _Pilot	One file per department: the crew list, each person's plan for every day (AM, PM, NIGHT and a whole-day WD row), currency, syllabus and the month totals.
Master_Planner	The squadron's flights, no-flying days, squadron events, alert states, flight codes and the Crew Matrix. It is the one true list of flights.
Duty_Roster	Who does BDO on each day, and which department does SDO on each day.
Ops_Room	The day board: tails, seats, ATD and ATA, flown or cancelled, Ops Adds, flying restrictions, down-chits and the ATOM currency export.

HOW THE PLAN FLOWS

The **Master Planner** plans the flights. Each **department** copies its flights into its own planner and puts its people on them. The **Duty Planner** hands out BDO and SDO days, and each department copies its days too. The **Ops Room** reads all of it and fills the seats on the day's board by itself. Nobody has to retype anything.

1.2 Opening LODESTAR

1. Open the SharePoint folder **Program** and open the LODESTAR dashboard file in Edge.
2. The screen **"Which department are you from?"** appears. Each card shows when its file last changed and who changed it: green is today, amber is this week, red is a week or more ago.
3. Click your own card. Your file opens **for editing** and the other files open beside it **to view only**, so you can see the rest of the squadron.



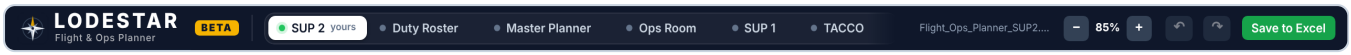
The department screen. The card you opened last is marked "You opened this last".

- The dashboard remembers your choice in this browser. To pick another card, click the **LODESTAR** logo at the top left.
- **⟳ Refresh** or F5 reads the latest files again and keeps you where you are.
- On SharePoint the dashboard looks for changes from other people every 15 seconds and shows them without you doing anything.

> **DASHBOARD AND FILES GO TOGETHER**
>
> The dashboard and the Excel files are made as a matched set. If a yellow bar says a file uses an **older layout** or is **newer than the dashboard**, tell the LODESTAR maintainer. Do not keep planning in a mixed set.

1.3 The screen

Top bar



The top bar.

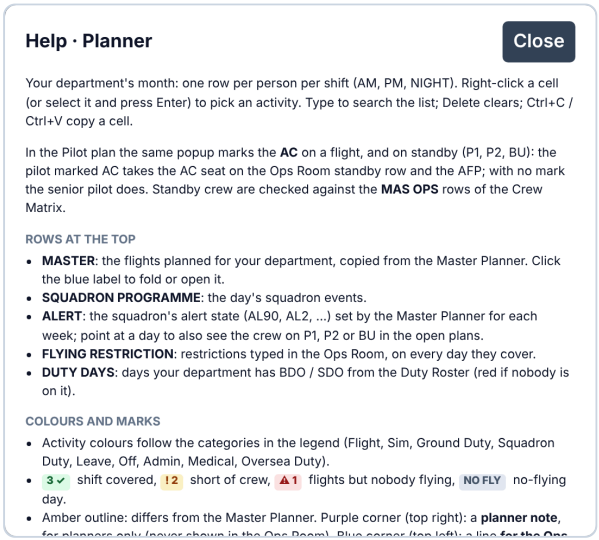
- **The file pills** list the open files. Yours is white and marked **yours**. A grey dot means view only.
- **− 100% +** zooms the whole page. Use it to fit the planner on a small screen.
- ↶ ↷ undo and redo.
- **Save to Excel** saves now. It turns bright green when there is something to save.

Tab bar



The tab bar. The padlock on Master Planner means you can look but not change it.

Tab	What it is
My Lodestar	Your own page: today's flight, your month, your currency and what changed. View only.
Planning ▾	Planner (the month plan), Overview, Syllabus Tracking and Miscellaneous Notes (the Department Planner guide).
Crew Roster, Currency, Activities	Your department's crew list, currency checks and activity list (the Department Planner guide).
Changelog	Every saved change, with who and when (section 1.4).
Ops Room	The day board (Part 2). Departments see it view only.
Master Planner ▾	The squadron calendar, Flight Codes and Crew Matrix (the Master Planner guide).
Duty Planner	BDO and SDO (the Department Planner guide).
?	Help for the page you are on, with the meaning of its colours.



The help (?) for the Planner.

1.4 Saving, undo and the Changelog

Saving

- **On SharePoint your work saves by itself** a few seconds after each change. `Save to Excel` saves at once.
- Only the cells you changed are written. The rest of the file, including its formulas and drop-downs, is left alone. If someone else saved the same file in the meantime, their changes are kept and yours are added on top.
- If you close the tab with unsaved changes, the browser asks you to confirm.

Undo and redo

`↶` and `↷`, or **Ctrl+Z** and **Ctrl+Y**, undo and redo your recent changes (up to 40 steps).

Changelog

Every save is written to a **Change Log** sheet in the file itself: when, who, what changed in words, and the value before and after. The `Changelog` tab shows the log of your own file, the Master Planner and the Ops Room. You can filter by person, file, day or text, and hover over a line to see the exact sheet and cell. Lines older than 90 days are dropped; SharePoint's version history keeps older copies of the file.

1.5 Who can change what

You opened	You can change	You can see
Your department	Your department's plan, Crew Roster, Currency, Activities, Syllabus and Notes.	Every other file, view only.
Master Planner	Flights, no-flying days, squadron events, alert states, Flight Codes and the Crew Matrix.	Every other file, view only.
Duty Roster	The BDO and SDO roster and the duty crew lists.	Every other file, view only.
Ops Room	The day board. It can also up-chit a person in a department file.	Every file.

On SharePoint this also follows the folder's edit rights. If you have no edit rights on a file, you cannot save it, even if you picked its card.

> **EXCEL STILL WORKS**
>
> You can open any of the files in desktop Excel to read or print them. Prefer the dashboard for changes: it keeps the copies between files in step. If you do edit in Excel, close the file before others save from the dashboard.

1.6 Common questions

Question	Answer
Everything is locked (🔒) and I cannot click.	You opened another department's card. Click the LODESTAR logo and pick your own.
I can't see a change someone just made.	Wait 15 seconds, or press ⟳ Refresh (F5).
A yellow bar says "older layout".	The files and the dashboard don't match. Tell the LODESTAR maintainer.
Save to Excel stays green.	The save did not go through. Check you are still signed in to SharePoint and have edit rights, then press it again.
The page is too big for my screen.	Use − in the top bar to zoom out.

PART 2

Ops Room

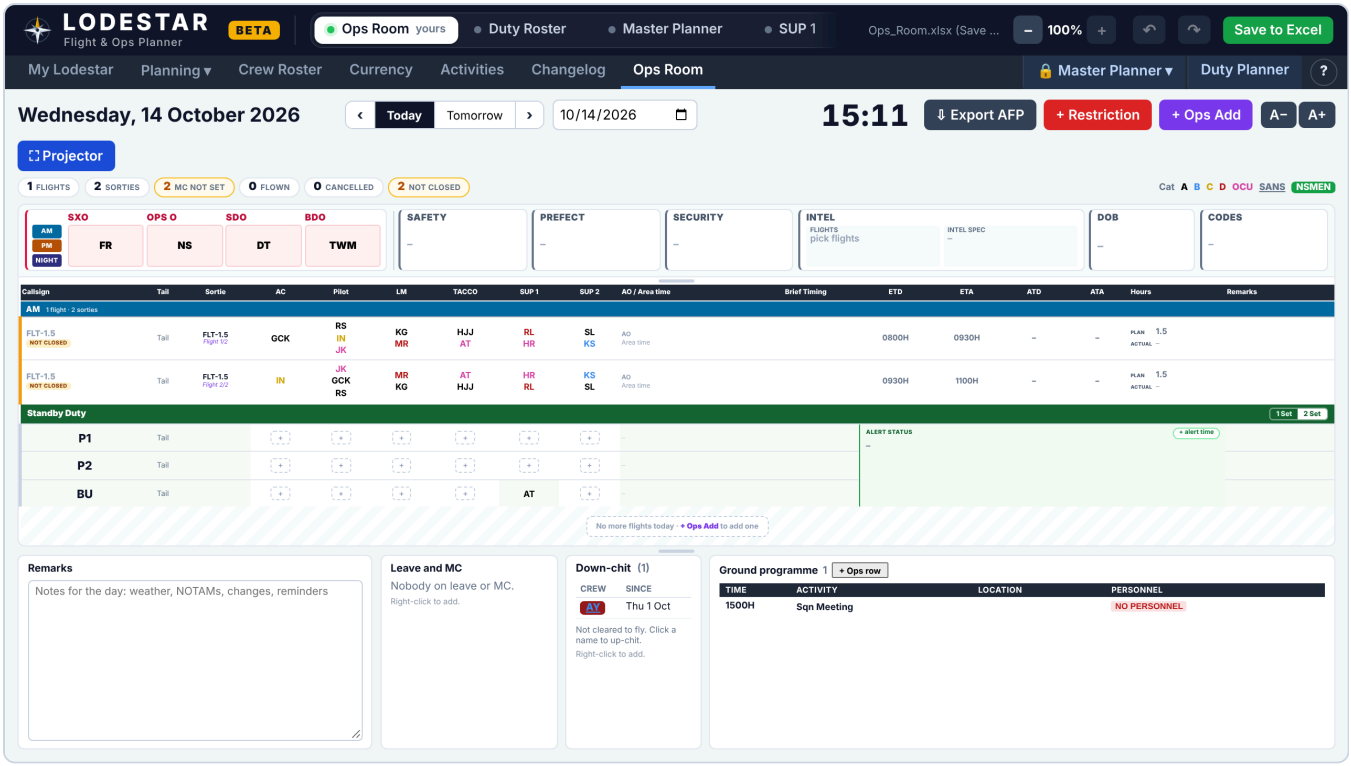
The day board for the SDO / AOS on duty and the projector

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QS Quick start

1. **Open the dashboard** and pick `Ops Room` on the department screen. Every file opens and the board shows today.
2. **Check the seats.** They fill themselves from the department plans. Click a seat to change it or mark MC / CRMO.
3. **Type the day's details**: tails, Brief Timing, the duty strip (Safety, Prefect, Security, Intel, DOB, Codes) and Remarks.
4. **Check the ground programme**: add the day's other ground activities with `+ Ops row`, and fix any NO PERSONNEL rows.
5. **Close every flight**: type ATD and ATA when it flew, or cancel it from its status pill with a reason.
6. **Once a day**, add the ATOM export and press **Publish to everyone**.
7. Press `⇩ Export AFP` when the AFP is needed.

2.1 Reading the board



The Ops Room, 14 October: a running change of 2 sorties, standby duty and the cards under the board.

- **‹ Today Tomorrow ›** and the date box move the day. The clock shows the time now.
- Flights are grouped in bands: **AM** blue, **PM** amber, **NIGHT** indigo. A running change has one row per sortie (Flight 1/2, Flight 2/2).
- The chips on top count the day: flights, sorties, MC not set, flown, cancelled, not closed. Click one to show only those flights; click it again to show all.
- Crew initials are coloured by their CAT (legend at the top right). A dashed **+** seat means nobody from that department is planned yet; it turns red when the flight is due (2 hours before ETD).
- **Hours** shows Plan above Actual. Actual is amber if longer than planned, green if shorter.
- **Remarks** on a flight show the lines planners marked **For the Ops Room**. Planner notes and the Master Planner's comment are not shown here.
- **A− A+** sizes the board. **Projector** hides the menus for the screen on the wall.

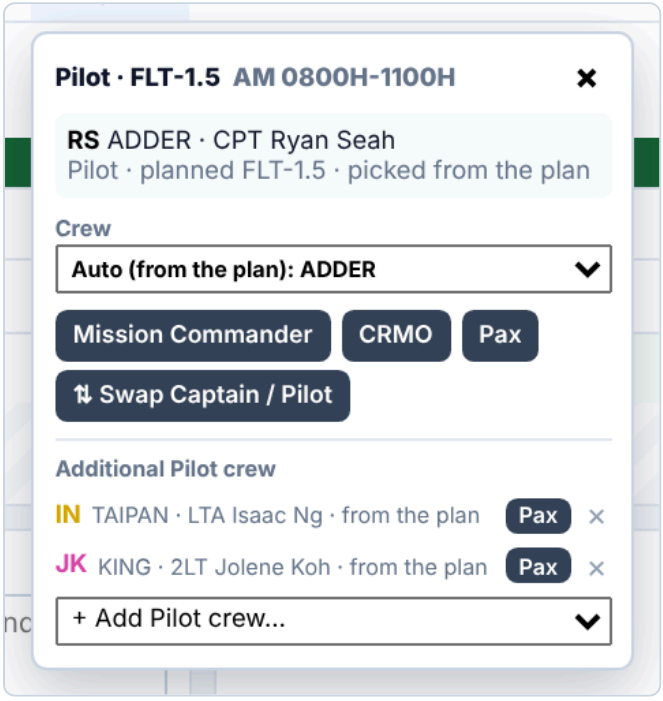
2.2 The duty strip



The duty strip at the top of the board.

- **SXO, OPS O and SDO** come from the plans, by shift (AM, PM, NIGHT). **BDO** is for the whole day.
- **Safety, Prefect, Security, DOB** and **Codes**: click and type. Enter starts a new line; Ctrl+Enter or clicking away saves.
- **Intel**: click **Flights** to tick the flights that need intel (it starts empty), and add other lines under the ticks.

2.3 Seats and crew



Clicking a seat.

The seats fill themselves from the department plans. The pilot marked AC (or else the senior pilot) takes the AC seat. Click a seat to:

- **Pick someone else** from the Crew list, or go back to **Auto (from the plan)**.
- Mark **Mission Commander** or **CRMO**.
- Mark someone **Pax**.
- **⇅ Swap Captain / Pilot**.
- See **Additional crew** from the plan, and **+ Add … crew**.

A **DOWN** seat means that person is down-chitted (MC). Click it to up-chit them or pick someone else.

Click a text cell (Callsign, Tail, AO / Area time, Brief Timing, Remarks) to type in it.

2.4 Closing a flight

Every flight should end the day **FLOWN** or **CANCELLED**. The pill under the callsign shows the status:

Status	Meaning
PLANNED	Planned. It counts as flown once ATD and ATA are filled.
DUE	Within 2 hours of ETD.
FLOWN	ATD and ATA are filled.
CANCELLED	Cancelled, with the reason.
NOT CLOSED	The flight is in the past and still open: fill ATD and ATA if it flew, or cancel it.
OPS ADD	An ad hoc flight added in the Ops Room (section 2.6).

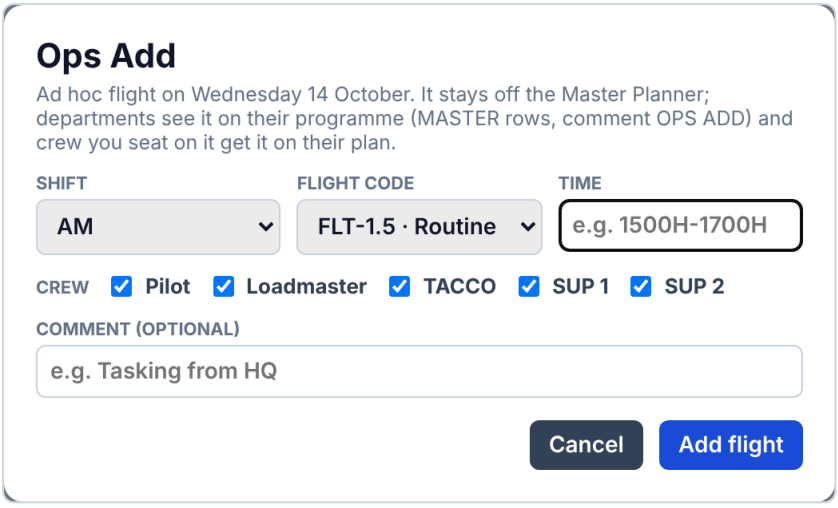
- **Flown:** type **ATD** and **ATA** in their columns.
- **Cancelled:** click the status pill, press **Cancel this flight** and type the reason. The flight is struck through on the department planners.

> **WHY IT MATTERS**
>
> The departments' currency checks count a past flight as flown until the Ops Room closes it. An open flight shows amber on their Planner and Currency pages.

2.5 Standby duty

- The green **Standby Duty** rows (P1, P2, BU) fill from the plans, like flights.
- **1 Set / 2 Set** at the right of the band chooses how many standby sets the day has.
- Each row has its own Brief Timing and Remarks. There is one **Alert status** box per shift; **+ alert time** adds a line.
- Standby crew are checked against the Crew Matrix (normally MAS OPS).

2.6 Ops Add



The Ops Add dialog.

+ Ops Add adds an ad hoc flight for the day: pick the shift, the flight code, the time, the departments that fly and an optional comment, then **Add flight**.

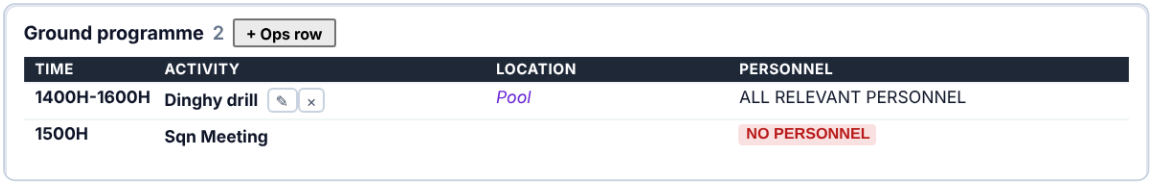
- It is not put on the Master Planner. Departments see it on their MASTER rows marked **OPS ADD**, and crew you seat on it get it on their plan.
- To remove it, click its status pill.

2.7 The cards under the board

Card	What it does
Remarks	Notes for the day: weather, NOTAMs, changes, reminders.
Leave and MC	Who is on leave, off or on MC today, from the plans. Right-click to add.
Down-chit	Who is not cleared to fly. Click a name to up-chit them. Right-click to add a down-chit. Up-chitting saves into that person's department file as well.
Ground programme	The day's squadron events and the Ops Room's own rows. See section 2.8.
Area & Codes	The day's areas, shown when they are filled in.

2.8 Ground programme

The **Ground programme** card under the board is the day's list of ground activities: it goes on the AFP and on the screen in the Ops Room. The Ops Room manages it.



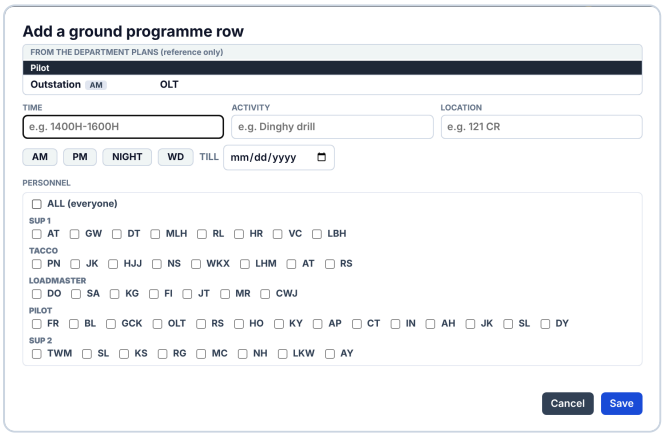
The Ground programme card. Point at a row to show ✎ (change) and ✕ (hide or delete).

Where the rows come from

Row	Where it comes from
Squadron events	Planned by the Master Planner (meetings, lectures, ceremonies). They show by themselves, with the event's time, place and who attends. **NO PERSONNEL** means the Master Planner did not choose who attends.
Ops rows	Added here by the Ops Room with **+ Ops row**, for anything else the squadron should see: a dinghy drill, a visit, a course.

The rows are in time order: clock times first, then AM, PM and NIGHT, then whole day, then items running on to a later day.

Add a row



Adding a row. The box at the top lists the departments' own ground items for the day, for reference.

1. Press **+ Ops row**.
2. **Time:** type a time or range (1400-1600 is saved as 1400H-1600H), or press **AM**, **PM**, **NIGHT** or **WD** (whole day).
3. For something that runs over several days, pick the last day in **TILL**. The row then shows on every day up to that date.
4. Type the **Activity** and the **Location**.
5. Tick **ALL (everyone)**, or tick the people by department.
6. Press **Save**. A row needs a time, an activity and the personnel.

The **From the department plans** box shows what the departments have planned for the day (for example a person on Outstation). It is there to help you fill the row; it is not added by itself.

Change, hide and delete

- ✎ changes a row. On a squadron event, only the fields you change are kept for this day; the rest still follow the Master Planner. The Master Planner's own event is not changed.
- ✕ on a squadron event **hides** it for this day only. **hidden (1)** under the table lists the hidden rows, with **Unhide**.

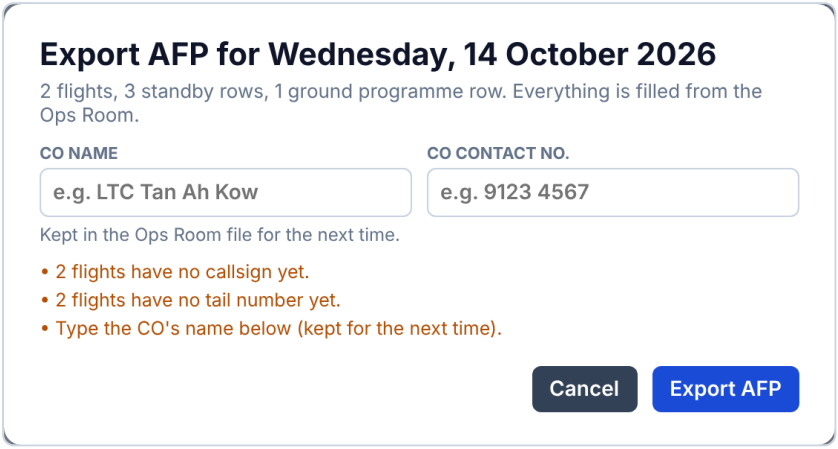
- ✕ on an Ops row **deletes** it.
- If the Master Planner later changes or removes an event you had changed, your row stays and is marked **was linked**. Check it, then change or delete it.

> **SAVED IN THE OPS ROOM FILE**
>
> Ops rows and changes are kept in the Ops Room file, so everyone sees them within about 15 seconds. They go on the AFP export (section 2.10).

2.9 Flying restrictions

+ Restriction adds a short notice for a range of dates, for example "No low flying in Area Echo". It shows as a red banner on the board, on the departments' FLYING RESTRICTION row and on the Master Planner calendar. On the banner, ✎ changes it and ✕ removes it.

2.10 Export AFP



The Export AFP dialog, with the items still missing.

⇩ Export AFP fills the squadron AFP format for the day on screen and downloads it as an Excel file.

- The dialog lists what is still missing, for example a flight with no callsign or tail number. Fix these first if you can.
- Type the CO's name and contact number once. They are kept for the next time.
- Names read Rank Name (CAT). Cancelled flights are left out. The brief time goes in the remarks.
- SXO, OPS O and SDO: line 1 of the box is AM, line 2 PM, line 3 NIGHT (one line means the whole day). Standby P1 is AM SAL, P2 is PM SAL.
- Prepared by is the SDO; Vetted by is the OPS O.

2.11 ATOM export

The Ops Room shares the day's ATOM currency data with the whole squadron:

1. Export the currency report from ATOM as usual.
2. In LODESTAR open the **Currency** tab and press **Add ATOM export**. Pick the file.
3. Press **Publish to everyone**. It is saved in the Ops Room file, and every department sees it within about 15 seconds.

Only the currency dates, the month's clocked hours and the mission currencies are kept, matched by initials. No names are stored. A banner turns amber when the data is 7 days old and red after 30, so do this once a day.

2.12 Questions and problems

Problem	What to do
"Not open, so their seats can't be filled: SUP 2".	That department's file did not open. Press ⟳ Refresh. If it stays, check the file is in the Program folder.
A seat is empty (dashed +).	Nobody from that department is planned on the flight. Ask the department, or click the seat and pick someone.
The wrong pilot is in the AC seat.	Click the seat and use Swap Captain / Pilot, or ask the Pilot planner to mark the AC.
A flight shows NOT CLOSED.	Fill ATD and ATA, or cancel it with a reason.
The ground programme shows NO PERSONNEL.	The Master Planner did not choose who attends the event. Ask them, or change the line with the pencil.
My change to a seat didn't stick.	Check Save to Excel is not still green. The Ops Room file needs edit rights.

> **HELP ON EVERY PAGE**
>
> The **?** button at the right end of the tab bar explains the Ops Room's colours and tools.